



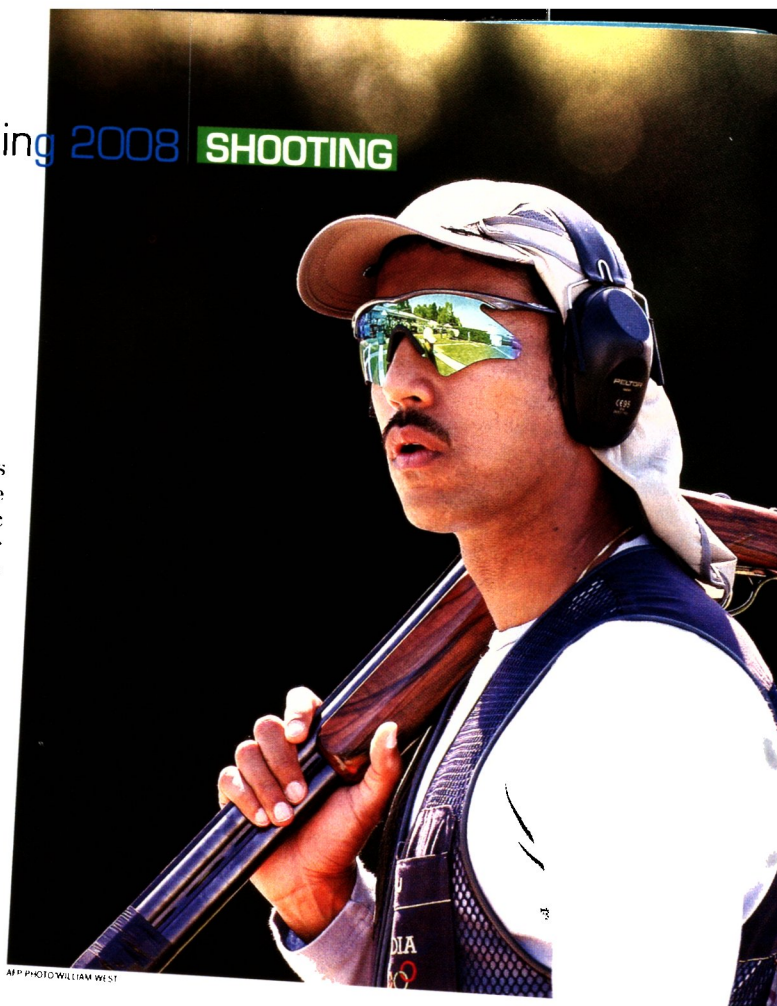
Beijing 2008 **SHOOTING**

With a silver medal at the Athens Olympics, the pressure is on the nine-member contingent to bring home a bucketful of medals

■ By Sharda Ugra

Detached from history and its heritage, it's all about a little piece of ribbon and a metal disc that is no thicker than a quarter of an inch. Its thickness is precisely calibrated—6mm; not a millimetre more, not a millimetre less. Good thing then that 10m rifle shooters know about millimetres: compared to that elusive, seductive 6mm thick Olympic medal, the diameter of their bull's eye is 0.5mm, just about the size of the full stop that finishes this sentence.

The difference between getting your hands on that ribbon and metal or just clutching at empty air rests on your ability as a shooter to look through your rifle sights and puncture the dead centre of a speck. "That's why I say that shooting is an extreme sport—you can't



AFP PHOTO/WILLIAM WEST

Company for CHILLY

miss one shot in 70," says Abhinav Bindra as emphatically as his lazy tones can summon up. Bindra is only 24, world champion in the 10m air rifle and Beijing is his third Olympics. He is one man in a nine-member Indian shooting team at the Games, the single bunch of athletes about whom it could unequivocally be said that India Expects.

Ever since Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore turned a clay target into a puff of pink dust in Athens four years ago, shooters are definitely the most elite of Indian Olympic athletes. The armyman's silver medal led to the sport's profile shooting up faster than any shotgun artist could yell "pull". The Government now sits up at the first murmur of complaint and the cheques have come churning out to

fund training runs and events, big or small. Within two years of Athens, India produced two World Champions, Bindra in the 10m air rifle and Manavjit Singh Sandhu in the trap.

Without the tempestuous hockey team acting as a buffer against expectation and attention, when these nine men and women stand at their shooting stations in Beijing, there will be one billion breaths on their necks. 'Chilly' Rathore has acted not merely as an inspiration, but it would seem as an alchemist too: his silver has turned India's dreams into gold.

Veteran trap shooter Mansher Singh says he can tell the difference that one medal has made to the shooting team as whole. "This is a very public event—unlike even our World

Championships. We know if we don't perform, questions are going to be asked in Parliament," he says.

Bindra is trying to detach himself from the idea of the wretched medal and treat the Games "like it's another event". Oh yeah, just like those India-Pakistan cricket matches. When compared to the shooting world championships, the Olympics should feel dwarfed in terms of entrants. Even the highest quality World Cup competitions sprinkled around the calendar have more competitors.

At an Olympics, the shooting event is held far away from the heart of the Games, out in open country where it's safe to fire at things. The rifle shooters in their weighted jackets and ear plugs, line up in long, cold rooms and all you